

MY SELF-CARE PLAN



Everyone has bad days. What counts is how we deal with those downer days. Will you perpetuate the negative spiral, or will you pick yourself back up again?

This worksheet is a tool kit for your worst days. Answer the questions now, and when you start feeling down, come back to these prompts to start feeling like yourself again.

1. List 10 things you are grateful for in life:

2. Describe the perfect day of your dreams:

3. What one, realistic thing could you do for yourself today that captures the essence of your fantasy day?

4. What is the best compliment you've ever received? What has someone said to you that always makes you smile?

5. What was your favorite thing to do as a kid? How could you recreate that activity as an adult?

Positive Traits

Kind	Insightful	Sensitive
Intelligent	Funny	Organized
Hardworking	Patient	Selfless
Loyal	Realistic	Practical
Attractive	Honest	Mature
Down-to-Earth	Generous	Focused
Goofy	Modest	Courteous
Creative	Serious	Grateful
Accepting	Independent	Open-Minded
Strong	Trusting	Positive
Friendly	Resilient	Responsible
Flexible	Cheerful	Cooperative
Nurturing	Self-Directed	Frugal
Thoughtful	Reliable	Tolerant
Confident	Relaxed	Innovative
Optimistic	Listener	Balanced
Respectful	Brave	
Determined	Decisive	
Skilled	Enthusiastic	
Helpful	Forgiving	
Motivated	Humble	

About Me

Sentence Completion



I was really happy when... _____



Something that my friends like about me is... _____



I'm proud of... _____



My family was happy when I... _____



In school, I'm good at... _____



Something that makes me unique is... _____

Positive Experiences

Write briefly about times when you have displayed each of the following qualities.

❖ **Courage**

❖ **Kindness**

❖ **Selflessness**

❖ **Love**

❖ **Sacrifice**

❖ **Wisdom**

❖ **Happiness**

❖ **Determination**

My Strengths and Qualities

Things I am good at:

1

2

3

Compliments I have received:

1

2

3

What I like about my appearance:

1

2

3

Challenges I have overcome:

1

2

3

I've helped others by:

1

2

3

Things that make me unique:

1

2

3

What I value the most:

1

2

3

Times I've made others happy:

1

2

3

Why I'm Grateful



I am grateful for my family because... _____



Something good that happened this week... _____



I am grateful for my friendship with... _____ because... _____



I am grateful for who I am because... _____



Something silly that I am grateful for... _____

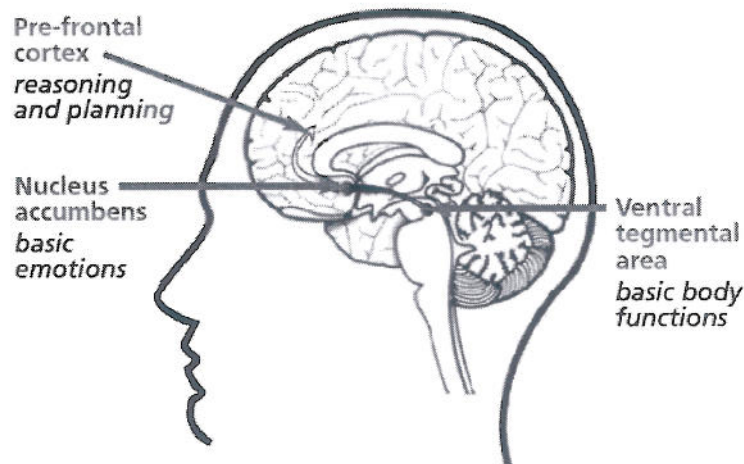


Something else I am grateful for... _____

Why it feels like you can't live without drugs or alcohol

Our brains are wired so that when we do something that gives us pleasure, we tend to want to do it again. That's what drives us to do things that help us survive — eating, for example. Almost all drugs that are used to get high change how the natural chemicals work in the brain's pleasure centre. This change tricks you into thinking that the drug is something you need for survival. Often, the changes in brain chemistry that drugs cause last longer than the high. That can cause serious long-term problems, including withdrawal symptoms and brain damage.

REWARD CIRCUIT



This is a picture of the reward circuit in the brain. The most important thing to notice is that the reward circuit has strong connections to the part of your brain that is responsible for basic emotions (the nucleus accumbens) and the part of your brain that regulates basic body functions (the ventral tegmental area). One of the reasons that addictive drugs have such a strong effect is that they act on the part of the brain that is in charge of very basic survival instincts. When the urge to use the drug is strong enough, this part of the

brain can override the part of the brain in charge of reasoning and planning (pre-frontal cortex). This is one reason why most drugs make the problem of being impulsive — acting without thinking — worse. This is also why people spend a lot of time and energy getting the drug they abuse for a short-term high, even though it causes a lot of problems in the long run.

When I am Tempted to Use

Check off the situations in which you would be most tempted to use drugs or alcohol. Write in your own situations if you don't see them listed.

- ___ When I am having withdrawals
- ___ When I want to have just one drink
- ___ When I want to see if I can handle using in moderation
- ___ When I have a headache
- ___ When I am worrying about something
- ___ When I have a dream about drugs
- ___ When I am tired
- ___ When I'm in pain
- ___ When I'm depressed
- ___ When I'm angry
- ___ When I want to relax
- ___ When I'm at a party
- ___ When I see drugs and alcohol on TV
- ___ When I'm happy
- ___ When my friends are using
- ___ When I am on vacation
- ___ When I am bored

People, Places, and Things

People, places, and things that remind us of our past drug use can trigger relapse. Driving past an old bar, hanging out with certain friends, or listening to an old song can bring back memories of using. List the people, places, and things you should avoid to reduce your risk of relapse.

People

Places

Things

Triggers



Trigger: A stimulus—such as a person, place, situation, or thing—that contributes to an unwanted emotional or behavioral response.

The Problem

Describe the problem your triggers are contributing to. What's the worst-case scenario, if you are exposed to your triggers?

Trigger Categories

Just about *anything* can be a trigger. To begin exploring your own triggers, think about each of the categories listed below. Is there a specific emotion that acts as a trigger for you? How about a person or place? List your responses in the provided spaces.

Emotional State	
People	
Places	
Things	
Thoughts	
Activities / Situations	

Tips for Dealing with Triggers

- Oftentimes, the best way to deal with a trigger is to avoid it. This might mean making changes to your lifestyle, relationships, or daily routine.
- Create a strategy to deal with your triggers head on, just in case. Your strategy might include coping skills, a list of trusted people you can talk to, or rehearsed phrases to help you get out of a troublesome situation.
- Don't wait until the heat of the moment to test your coping strategy. *Practice!*

Triggers



In this section, you will develop a plan for dealing with your three biggest triggers. Review your plan regularly, and practice each of the strategies.

Describe your three biggest triggers, in detail.

Trigger	#1	
	#2	
	#3	

Describe your strategy for *avoiding or reducing exposure* to each trigger.

Trigger	#1	
	#2	
	#3	

Describe your strategy for dealing with each trigger head on, when they cannot be avoided.

Trigger	#1	
	#2	
	#3	

Coping Skills

Addictions

Social Support

Few things are as powerful as having a supportive person in your corner. Just knowing that friends, family, or even a fellow group member or sponsor are pulling for you can make all the difference.

Daily Social Support

There's more to social support than having someone to call during moments of crisis. People who have strong relationships are more resilient when facing life's obstacles, and more likely to beat addiction. Make a point to strengthen your relationships, attend support groups, and build new friendships.

Crisis Social Support

When in crisis, it's helpful to have a person you can count on for support—someone who you can call, who will help to talk you through the situation. Make a list of people who you can contact during these situations, and how you can reach them.

Diversions

Cravings are brutal. They grow and grow, gnawing at your willpower, demanding that you relapse. In the middle of a craving, it might feel as if there's no escape but to use. But then, if you resist, the craving starts to fade. Eventually, it disappears. Most cravings end within one hour of starting.

The goal of **diversions** is to buy yourself time during a craving. If you can distract yourself for just *one hour*, you will have a much better chance of avoiding relapse. Come up with a list of activities you genuinely enjoy that will keep you at a distance from your temptation.

Diversion Ideas

go for a walk	read a book	play a sport	listen to music
watch a movie	practice a hobby	go for a run	clean or organize
do yard work	draw or paint	do a craft	cook or bake
play a game	go for a bicycle ride	write or journal	take a long bath
play an instrument	call a friend	lift weights	go swimming
go hiking in nature	take photographs	play with a pet	rearrange a room

Coping Skills

Addictions

Building New Habits

Most addictions require a *lot* of time. Thinking about, acquiring, and indulging an addiction can fill most of a day. When you quit, one of your greatest new resources is time. However, if your newfound time isn't filled with healthy activities, it will pose a risk for falling back into old habits.

Building new habits is different than diversion because of the focus on long-term or permanent life changes. This isn't about riding out a craving—this is about building a better life for yourself.

Foster New Relationships

- Join a casual sports league.
- Attend a local meetup for one of your interests or hobbies.
- Get involved in your community by volunteering or supporting a cause you care about.

Develop New Professional Skills

- Return to school to pursue a subject you are interested in.
- Find a full-time job, or seek a new career that you enjoy.
- Build new skills on your own using free online resources, or practice your existing skills.

Refocus on Existing Relationships

- Build a routine around socializing with friends and family. For example, have Sunday dinners with family, and evening walks with a friend.
- Be proactive—don't wait for others to reach out to you.
- Say "yes" to every social invitation that will not put you at risk of relapse.

Prevention

Avoid Triggers / Risky Situations

Don't wait until you're in a bad situation to figure out how to escape it. Instead, avoid those situations altogether. Create a list of the people, places, and things that will likely lead to relapse, and come up with a plan to avoid them in the future. Sometimes this is as simple as taking a different route home from work, and other times it might mean a significant lifestyle change.

Healthy Lifestyle

A healthy lifestyle will make you more resilient when faced with obstacles. Many unhealthy habits, such as insufficient sleep and exercise, have been closely linked to many forms of mental illness. Focus on creating a routine that accounts for the following aspects of a healthy lifestyle:

- Sleep
- Exercise
- Medical Compliance (e.g. taking medications as prescribed and attending appointments)
- Healthy Diet

Coping Skills

Addictions

Managing Emotions / Relaxation

Most addictions serve as an escape from uncomfortable emotions such as stress, anxiety, and anger. When the crutch of addiction is taken away, you may need to re-learn how to manage your emotions. If you don't learn how to relax, tension will build and build, until it leads to relapse. These techniques, when practiced regularly, will help you manage your emotions in a healthy way.

Deep Breathing

Deep breathing is a simple technique that's excellent for managing emotions. Sit comfortably and place one hand on your abdomen. Breathe in deeply enough that your hand begins to rise and fall. Imagine you are trying to completely fill your lungs with air. Time the inhalation (4s), pause (4s), and exhalation (6s) during every breath. Practice for 3 to 5 minutes at a time.



Journaling

Writing about personal experiences gives your brain the opportunity to process information and organize it into manageable chunks. Some of the many benefits of journaling include improved mental wellbeing, and the reduction of uncomfortable emotions. As you journal, be sure to describe your feelings alongside the facts of your experiences.

Feel free to journal however you like. However, if you feel stuck, try these prompts:

- **Daily Log:** Jot a few notes about each day. Whatever comes to mind is fine.
- **Letter:** Write a letter to someone with whom you would like to tell something. Remember to describe your feelings. *Do not send the letter!*
- **Gratitude:** Describe three good things from your day, no matter how minor they seem.

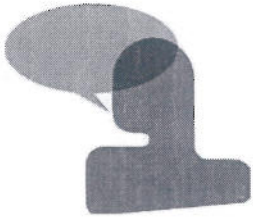
Imagery

Your brain has the power to turn thoughts into real emotions, and physical responses. Think about it: Your mouth waters at the thought of your favorite food, and a happy memory can make you laugh. With the imagery technique, you will use this power to your advantage.

Take a moment to think of a relaxing location or situation. This could be a memory, or something entirely made up. Maybe you're on a warm beach, alone at the top of a mountain, or at dinner with close friends. Next, imagine this scene through each of your senses. Don't just think about each detail for a second and move on—really imagine them. What do you see? What sounds do you hear? What do you feel? What smells are around you?

Use imagery for at least 5 minutes whenever you need a quick escape.

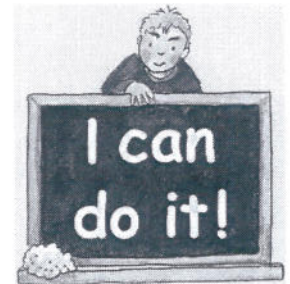
Positive Self- talk / Coping Thoughts Worksheet



Positive statements encourage us and help us cope through distressing times. We can say these encouraging words to ourselves, and be our own personal coach. We have all survived some very distressing times, and we can use those experiences to encourage us through current difficulties.

Examples of coping thoughts might be:

- Stop, and breathe, I can do this
- This will pass
- I can be anxious/angry/sad and still deal with this
- I have done this before, and I can do it again
- This feels bad, it's a normal body reaction – it will pass
- This feels bad, and feelings are very often wrong
- These are just feelings, they will go away
- This won't last forever
- Short term pain for long term gain
- I can feel bad and still choose to take a new and healthy direction
- I don't need to rush, I can take things slowly
- I have survived before, I will survive now
- I feel this way because of my past experiences, but I am safe right now
- It's okay to feel this way, it's a normal reaction
- Right now, I am not in danger. Right now, I'm safe
- My mind is not always my friend
- Thoughts are just thoughts – they're not necessarily true or factual
- This is difficult and uncomfortable, but it's only temporary
- I can use my coping skills and get through this
- I can learn from this and it will be easier next time
- Keep calm and carry on



Yes!

Write down a coping thought or positive statement for each difficult or distressing situation – something you can tell yourself that will help you get through. Write them down on a piece of card and carry it in your pocket or handbag to help remind you.

Difficult or distressing situation	Coping thought / Positive statement

How To Create A Mantra

We all get overwhelmed sometimes, and when we think too much about our anxieties about the future we prevent ourselves from taking care of our own present moment. When you begin to feel overwhelmed or anxious about the future, remind yourself of your mantra.

Follow the steps below to create your own mantra:

Reflect

Take 20-45 minutes reflecting on how you feel, what is going on around you, and where your anxiety is coming from. Develop a deep understanding of the issue. Use the space below to journal your key notes for developing your mantra.

Consider

It can be rough at times in life, and it can be easy to forget those lessons we have learned growing up that help us have confidence in our future and ourselves. What do you know about yourself and the world around you that will help bring you confidence in your abilities to overcome challenges?

Create

It is time to create your mantra. Create a mantra, or saying, to remind yourself of what you need to remember when you feel anxious, upset or overwhelmed. It will need to be a mantra that you can easily remember and recall, so try to keep it to one short sentence.

For example:

"I am stronger than my anxiety."

"I will get through this."

"This too, shall pass."



Tips for Avoiding Relapse

The most important moment before relapse isn't the final decision to use a drug. It's when you decide to expose yourself to triggers. For example, a trigger could be going to a party or walking through the liquor section at the store. Before encountering your triggers, *you* still have most of the control. Not your craving.

If you're feeling the urge to use, try to wait it out. If you distract yourself for even 30 minutes, it's likely your craving will lessen in intensity. It might not totally disappear, but it will become easier to resist.

Focus on replacing your past drug use with new positive activities. If you used to go home after work and drink, you'll need to make a new plan to occupy yourself. Going home and staring at a wall will eventually lead to staring at a wall with a drink in your hand.

Don't try to do this alone. Sharing your goals for sobriety with a friend makes all the difference. They can hold you accountable when you're making questionable decisions ("I'm just going to the bar to hang out, I won't drink!") and they can offer a kind ear when you're struggling.

Remind yourself that cravings will pass. Have you ever had that experience when you're sick where you can't remember what it feels like to *not* be sick? The same thing happens with cravings. Give it time, and believe it or not, the feeling will go away.

You'll have to make sacrifices beyond giving up the drug. If you previously used during specific activities (for example: watching a game on TV, going to concerts, or spending time with friends), you may need to make changes. This might mean *not* watching the game, or making new friends who are sober. This can be really hard, but that's what makes it a sacrifice.

Have a plan for when things get bad, because at some point, they will. People get fired, hearts get broken, and sometimes people leave us forever. Develop a plan to get through these major life challenges--without the use of drugs--before they happen.

Don't become complacent with your sobriety. If you someday consider having "just a glass of wine with dinner", don't make the decision lightly. If you've struggled with addiction in the past, you are much more likely to develop an addiction again.

If you do relapse, don't give up. A lot of people find it helpful to keep track of how long they've been sober, but don't confuse this count with the true goal of leading a good life. If you're at day 100 of sobriety, that's great. However, if you make a mistake and end up back at day 0, know that you are not starting over (you gained knowledge, experience, and confidence). In other words: Slipping up is not a license to go on a binge.

Come up with new rituals. How do you celebrate holidays, promotions, or any other happy occasion? If your answer includes any sort of drug, you'll want to get creative and figure out something new. Go wild with a hobby for the day, treat yourself to a nice dinner, or take a weekend trip. Make sure it's something you can get excited about.

Relapse Prevention Plan

Five warning signs that I might use:

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.

Five people who I can call to help me get through a craving:

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.

Five things I can do to get my mind off of using:

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.

Relapse Prevention Plan

Coping Skills: List activities or skills you enjoy that can get your mind off of using.

1	
2	
3	

Social Support: Who are three people you can talk to if you are thinking about using?

1	
2	
3	

Consequences: How will your life change if you relapse? How about if you stay sober?

Outcomes of Relapse	Outcomes of Sobriety

Tips to avoid relapse:

- Cravings will eventually pass. Do your best to distract yourself and ride it out.
- Don't become complacent. Relapse can happen years after you've quit using. It probably won't ever be safe to "just have one".
- Avoid situations that you know will put you at risk of relapse, such as spending time with friends who use drugs or going places that remind you of your past use.
- The decision to relapse is made when you put yourself in risky situations, long before you actually use.
- Don't view relapse as a failure. Falling back into old patterns because of a slip will only make the situation worse.

Coping Skills

Below are some options for general coping. Remember to incorporate other coping skills that you have used or have previously found to be helpful.

Self Soothing

Breathing:

Take deep breaths from the diaphragm or stomach. Breathe in then, when you breathe out; very slowly release your breath out.

Exercise:

Change your focus, get your body moving

Music:

Use a relaxing or lively tune or music that inspires you. Consider dancing.

Relax your body:

Progressive muscle relaxation. Download guided relaxation. Take a bath or shower. Do yoga.

Comfort Item:

Hold onto or wrap yourself in something comforting – a blanket, jacket, scarf, stuffed animal – anything that helps you feel more comfortable.

Imagery:

Look at and direct your attention towards picture or photograph of a beautiful and calming scene (i.e., beach, mountains).

Visualization:

Visualize a place you love, either that you have been at, or that you enjoy imagining yourself to be there. Describe it paying attention to using all five senses (e.g., the beach: what it looks like, how the sand feels, what it sounds like: wind and waves, salt water smell).

Do Something Positive

Do One Positive Thing.

Do something positive for yourself or for someone else. Every day is an opportunity to do something to move you towards your goals or towards being more positive.

Socialize:

Call someone and talk about something pleasant, encourage them to talk about something pleasant, plan to do something pleasant,...

Call someone and vent about what is bothering you – but keep it time-limited.

Entertain yourself:

Computer game, crossword, cards, jigsaw, cook, read books, magazines, etc, do crafts, sudoku.....

List your achievements

What have you done that was challenging for you, what have you put effort into, what have people said you do well....

Prayer

Use whatever prayers, rituals, spiritually inspiring readings, music or activities that get you in touch with something bigger than yourself.

Problem Solving

Is there something you can do towards solving the problem?

Dealing with your thoughts and assumptions

Self-statements/Cognitive Coping:

What can you say to yourself to help you feel better?

Examples include, "I'm safe now; he's not here; It's not my fault. I can get through this."

You already survived your past.

Use your skills to identify the thoughts bothering you and see if you can identify an alternative true way to think about what is happening.

Redirect Unhelpful Thoughts:

Notice if you have a lot of self-critical or otherwise discouraging thoughts. Push these away and identify something positive you can do.

What would your mentor say?

Whom do you admire? What do you imagine they would say to encourage you?

Reality Check:

Is there something I need to do about this right now?

Is there something I could do about this right now?

Is there another way to think about this?

Radical Acceptance

Lifeline – is there someone else I can talk to about my options?

Distracting

Focus on your Senses Right now

Identify something you see, something you hear, something you smell, something you touch. While doing this stay mindfully focused on just your senses in the moment. Describe what you are sensing. Look at something specific. Smell something strong (scented lotion, candle, oil, spices). Touch different textures – not just with your hands – use your face, your feet, etc. Taste something minty or strong flavored, and/or brush your teeth.

Mindful Eating:

Examine food (e.g., 1 raisin), watch hand move towards your mouth, take a moment to smell it, how body reacting to smell (e.g., mouth watering), how is food positioned in mouth? Begin chewing slowly, what tastes experiencing? When you swallow, feel muscles contract as you push food to your stomach, be aware of sensations (Can eat with non-dominant hand to increase awkwardness and increase likelihood you'll have to pay attention).

Mindful Walking:

Walk slowly and carefully feeling your feet connect at each point on the floor. Without controlling breath too much, you can try pairing walking and breathing so that 1 foot touches the ground at each *in* and *out* breath. See how many steps seem natural to take during each inhalation and exhalation. Direct all attention towards the sensations of walking: your feet and lower legs. Which part touches the ground first? Pay attention to how your weight shifts from one foot to the other. What are the feelings in your knees as they bend? What is the texture of the ground (hard, soft, cracks, stones)? What are differences in walking on different surfaces?

Your Ideas:

Mindfulness Exercises



Mindfulness Meditation

Find a place where you can sit quietly and undisturbed for a few moments. To begin, you might want to set a timer for about 10 minutes, but after some experience you should not be too concerned about the length of time you spend meditating.

Begin by bringing your attention to the present moment by noticing your breathing. Pay attention to your breath as it enters and then leaves your body. Before long, your mind will begin to wander, pulling you out of the present moment. That's ok. Notice your thoughts and feelings as if you are an outside observer watching what's happening in your brain. Take note, and allow yourself to return to your breathing.

Sometimes you might feel frustrated or bored. That's fine—these are just a few more feelings to notice. Your mind might start to plan an upcoming weekend, or worry about a responsibility. Notice where your thoughts are going, and accept what's happening.

Whenever you are able to, return your concentration to your breathing. Continue this process until your timer rings, or until you are ready to be done.



Body Scan

During the body scan exercise you will pay close attention to physical sensations throughout your body. The goal isn't to change or relax your body, but instead to notice and become more aware of it. Don't worry too much about how long you practice, but do move slowly.

Begin by paying attention to the sensations in your feet. Notice any sensations such as warmth, coolness, pressure, pain, or a breeze moving over your skin. Slowly move up your body—to your calves, thighs, pelvis, stomach, chest, back, shoulders, arms, hands, fingers, neck, and finally your head. Spend some time on each of these body parts, just noticing the sensations.

After you travel up your body, begin to move back down, through each body part, until you reach your feet again. Remember: move slowly, and just pay attention.



Mindful Eating

Choose a food you would like to practice with (preferably something you can hold in your hand without getting messy). Something as simple as a single raisin will work well. Move slowly through these steps, taking a moment to focus on each one.

Before you pick up your food, notice how it looks on the table in front of you. Notice its color, how the light reflects from its surface, and its size.

Mindfulness Exercises

Now, pick up the food. Notice the weight, and how the food feels against your skin. Roll the object between your fingers, or roll it in your hand, and notice its texture. Notice if it's smooth, rough, slick, soft, firm or if it has any other properties. Hold the food to your nose, and pay attention to its smell.

Next, place the food in your mouth, on your tongue, but don't eat it. Notice how it feels in your mouth. Does the texture feel the same as on your hand? What do you taste? Roll the food around in your mouth and pay attention to the feeling.

Finally, begin to slowly chew your food. Notice how your teeth sink into it, and how the texture is different inside. Pay close attention to the flavor, and how it spreads across your tongue. Notice how your body changes—does your mouth fill with saliva? Does your tongue feel hot or cold? Continue to chew your food, paying close attention to the many sensations as you finish.



Five Senses

Use this exercise to quickly ground yourself in the present when you only have a moment. The goal is to notice something that you are currently experiencing through each of your senses.

What are 5 things you can see? Look around you and notice 5 things you hadn't noticed before. Maybe a pattern on a wall, light reflecting from a surface, or a knick-knack in the corner of a room.

What are 4 things you can feel? Maybe you can feel the pressure of your feet on the floor, your shirt resting on your shoulders, or the temperature on your skin. Pick up an object and notice its texture.

What are 3 things you can hear? Notice all the background sounds you had been filtering out, such as an air-conditioning, birds chirping, or cars on a distant street.

What are 2 things you can smell? Maybe you can smell flowers, coffee, or freshly cut grass. It doesn't have to be a nice smell either: maybe there's an overflowing trash can or sewer.

What is 1 thing you can taste? Pop a piece of gum in your mouth, sip a drink, eat a snack if you have one, or simply notice how your mouth tastes. "Taste" the air to see how it feels on your tongue.

The numbers for each sense are only a guideline. Feel free to do more or less of each. Also, try this exercise while doing an activity like washing dishes, listening to music, or going for a walk.